

# Making *responsible* technology feel human.

A complete brand identity system and website experience designed for the Responsible Technology & Society Lab at ASU — from competitive analysis and brand strategy to high-fidelity prototype.

| PROJECT                      | AGENCY     | ROLE            | TEAM                                                                       | DELIVERABLES         |
|------------------------------|------------|-----------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------|
| RTS Lab Visual Identity & UX | Team IGNIS | Project Manager | İdil Kale · Khadija Osman · Jasvitha Madine · Alex Yusupov · Joshua Stubbs | Brand System + UX/UI |

# The brief: give a research lab the identity it deserved.

The RTS Lab studies how AI, automation, and global digital systems affect society. Their research is urgent. Their brand was invisible. Working as an independent creative agency, Team IGNIS was tasked with changing that.

## THE PROBLEM

No cohesive visual identity and no modern web presence. The challenge was creating something that could speak to academic researchers and the general public at the same time — without feeling generic or cold.

## WHAT THE CLIENT ASKED FOR

Bold strategy over safe design. The brief specifically called for human + technology integration visuals, global symbolism, inclusive themes, and a logo system that works across multiple formats and backgrounds.

## WHO WE WERE DESIGNING FOR

Researchers looking for credibility, students looking for approachability, industry partners looking for relevance, and policymakers who need to trust what they're reading. All at once.

## WHAT WE DELIVERED

A complete brand identity system, brand guidelines document, UX personas and user journey maps, sitemap, wireframes, and a fully interactive high-fidelity prototype for desktop and mobile.

# We studied the field before entering it.

| ORGANIZATION                       | VISUAL STYLE                    | STRENGTH                              | WEAKNESS                                  | TAKEAWAY FOR RTS                             |
|------------------------------------|---------------------------------|---------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------|
| Applied School Media Lab — Harvard | B&W, minimal, text-heavy        | Academic + modern                     | No sticky nav, no breadcrumbs             | Smart typography, simple research navigation |
| MIT Media Lab                      | Image-heavy, bright CTA hovers  | Immediate human connection via photos | Navigation tricky, info overload on pages | Images with people = human-centered feel     |
| PASCL — UBC                        | Single-section, simple palette  | Easy navigation, uniform interactions | All projects hosted externally            | Simplicity works when content is self-hosted |
| Stanford AI Lab                    | Very academic, minimal design   | Great branding, easy navigation       | —                                         | Consistent branding throughout all sections  |
| Cornell AI Initiative              | Academic, minimal color palette | Easy to understand content            | Unclear project categories in sections    | Dynamic text on scroll adds energy           |

**Key insight:** Every comparable lab either felt too cold and generic, or lacked visual consistency. None combined warmth with system-based thinking. That gap became our strategic opportunity.

# Before we opened Illustrator.

We made a rule early on: no visual decisions before the strategy was done. Everything here was written before a single color was picked.

## tone of voice

### Credible

Informed and clear — not trying to sound impressive

### Human-Centered

Talks about people, not just systems

### Forward-Looking

Relevant without sounding like a startup pitch

## MISSION

Explore how emerging technologies shape people and society — and make sure that shaping happens responsibly, ethically, and inclusively.

## STRENGTHS

- Strong, timely research focus: AI, automation, ethics, and social impact
- Interdisciplinary perspective spanning tech, behavior, policy, and society
- Clear human-centered mission that's easy to communicate
- Passionate team with a lot to say — just no visual system to say it with

## OPPORTUNITIES

- Public and academic interest in responsible AI is growing fast
- Most comparable labs look generic — real space to stand out visually
- Strong storytelling potential: ethics, inclusion, and human impact all resonate
- A distinctive identity could help attract collaborators and funding

## WEAKNESSES

- No cohesive visual identity — nothing to recognise or remember
- Subject matter can feel distant or overly technical to non-specialists
- Without careful communication, risks feeling like just another academic lab
- Visibility doesn't yet reflect the quality of the work being done

## THREATS

- Crowded AI space — differentiation critical
- Generic identity blends with competition
- Too technical risks disconnect
- Too abstract loses the message

## BRAND POSITIONING STATEMENT

*"For researchers, students, and policy-facing partners, the RTS Lab makes complex technological systems more understandable, ethical, and socially relevant — connecting innovation with real human impact."*

# Three early directions. One synthesis.

We explored three distinct directions before any group alignment. Each brought something different. After critique, the breakthrough was realizing we didn't need to choose between them — our final direction, Loop Layers, emerged by combining the warmth of Idea 1, the energy of Idea 2, and the structural thinking of Idea 3.

## Idea 1 — Layers of Connection



Soft overlapping forms and gradient nodes representing human relationships. Warm, inclusive, approachable.

↳ Contributed: warmth, human-centered feel

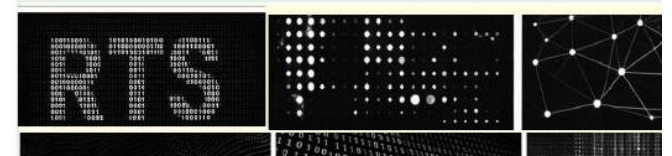
## Idea 2 — Feedback Loops



Movement, loops, and flowing structures representing technology as something active, shaped through continuous human interaction.

↳ Contributed: energy, motion, system thinking

## Idea 3 — Signal from Noise



Binary patterns and controlled distortion representing how the lab interprets complex technological systems.

↳ Contributed: structure, analytical depth

**Loop Layers** — the final direction — was not a fourth idea. It was the synthesis: combining layered human-centered visuals from Idea 1 with the flowing, system-based energy of Idea 2, refined through feedback from critique into something more focused, more cohesive, and more distinctly the RTS Lab's own.

# The logo took longer than we expected.



## Logo Typeface

Fira Sans Book — designed by Mozilla for digital readability. Chosen as a strategic signal: this lab's work is for everyone.

## Clear Space

Minimum 0.5× logo height on all sides. No elements may break the clear space boundary.

## Formats

.eps · .ai · .png · .jpg · .tiff — vector primary. Dark and light background variants required.

## Corporate Fonts

Montserrat Bold (headings) + Source Sans Pro Regular (body). Modern, structured, readable.

## DESIGN RATIONALE

### Why custom letterforms?

We wanted the logo to carry the concept. The circular, overlapping blob shapes echo the loop motif and make the monogram feel alive — not like something you could recreate by picking a font.

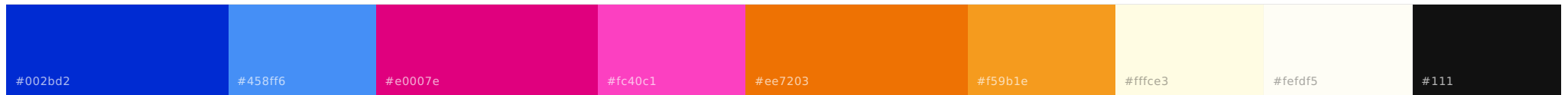
### Why these colors?

Most academic labs go safe: navy, teal, grey. We went the other way — electric blue, magenta, vivid orange. The warm cream background keeps it from feeling loud. Bold but grounded.

### Why Fira Sans?

It was designed by Mozilla specifically for digital readability — which felt right for a lab whose whole point is making technology more understandable. Clean, modern, legible at any size.

# A palette that earns its own attention.



Primary palette (larger) + tonal secondary variants. Secondary colors support layered and transparent visual language.

## Logo typeface — Fira Sans

# Fira Sans

ABCDEFGHIJKLMNOPQRSTUVWXYZ

abcdefghijklmnopqrstuvwxyz

0 1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9

## Corporate type system

# Montserrat Bold

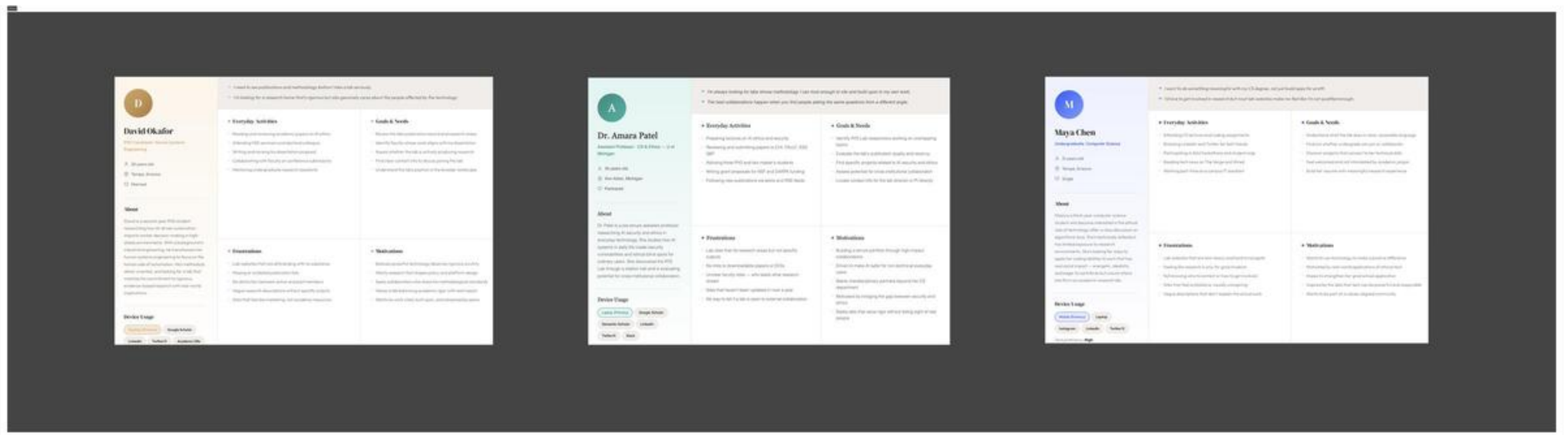
Headlines, section titles, strong emphasis

## Source Sans Pro Regular

Body copy, UI labels, captions — maximum readability

# We designed for real people with real goals.

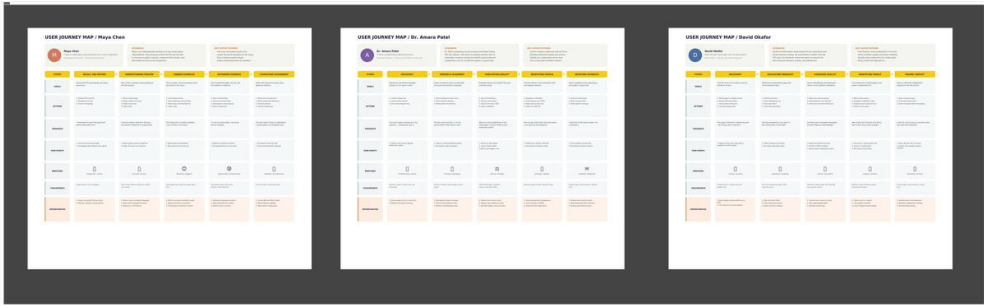
Three distinct personas shaped every navigation and content decision. Not guesses — each one is based on the actual goals and frustrations of the people who'd use this site.



David Okafor (PhD candidate, HSE) · Dr. Amara Patel (Assistant Professor, AI Ethics) · Maya Chen (Undergraduate CS student).

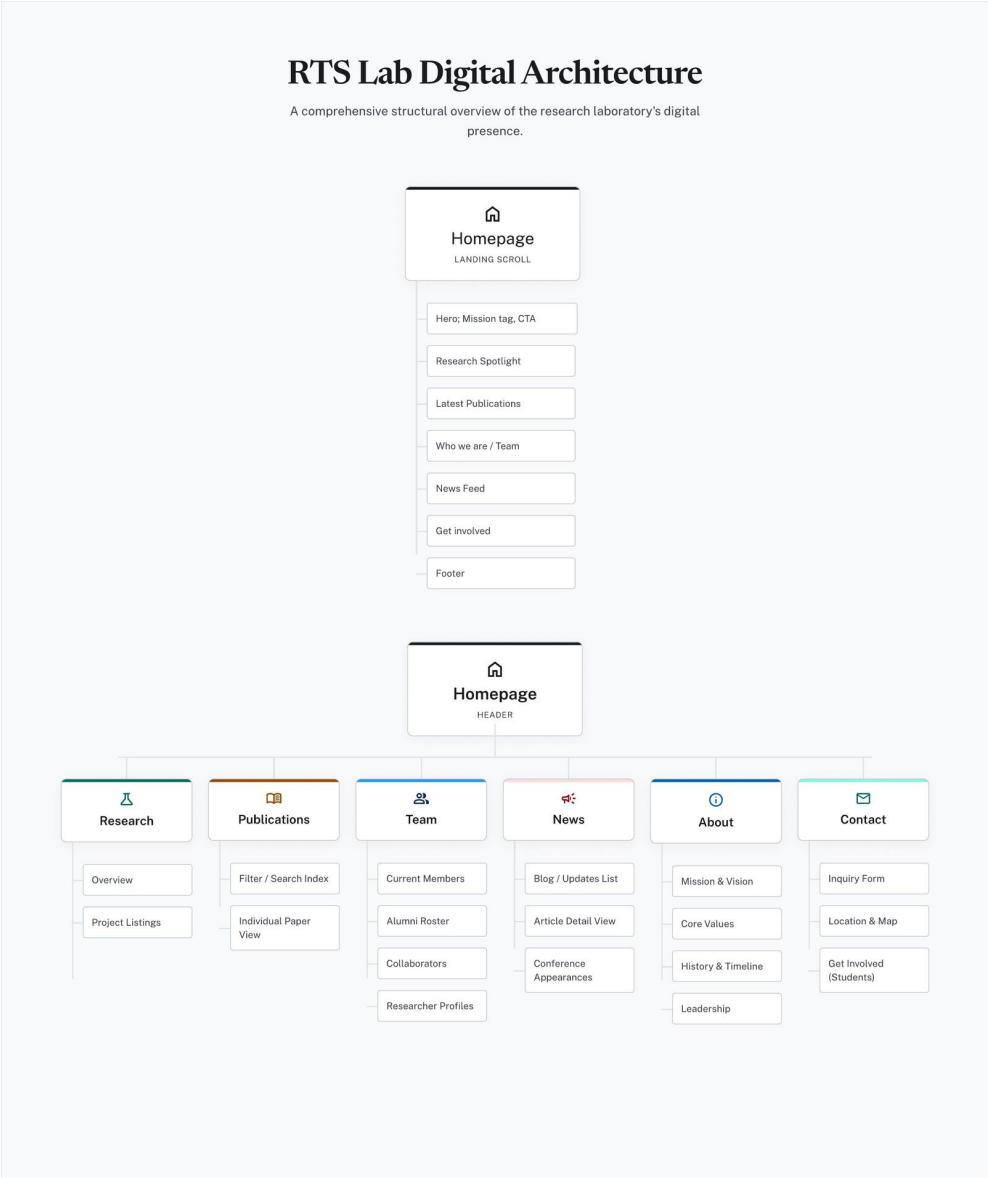


User Journey Maps



Full journey mapping: Discovery → Research → Publication/Contact. Pain points informed sitemap decisions — especially filtering on Publications and the "Get Involved" CTA placement.

Information Architecture



6 primary sections: Research · Publications · Team · News · About · Contact. Every page justified by a specific user need identified in the persona and journey research.

# How we got there.

- **Individual concept exploration**

Each of the five team members developed three concepts independently before any group discussion. That gave us 15 genuinely different starting points — and meant our final agency directions were actually distinct from each other.

- **Research before visuals**

We audited five comparable labs (Harvard, MIT, Stanford, Cornell, UBC), ran a SWOT analysis, defined four target audiences, and wrote the brand positioning statement — all before opening Illustrator.

- **Critique and a key constraint**

After presenting three directions, the feedback that stuck: don't go too abstract, don't go too generic. That tension shaped every decision that came after — including how we eventually combined the three ideas into Loop Layers.

- **Identity — two rounds of revision**

The logo took several letterform explorations to get right. The color palette started too muted and needed pushing. Each round of feedback made it more cohesive — and more clearly ours.

- **UX: research → wireframes → prototype**

Three personas and three journey maps informed the sitemap. Wireframes in Figma for all six pages, then high-fidelity desktop and mobile designs with Auto Layout and the full brand system applied.

- **Final delivery**

Brand guidelines in InDesign, logo files in all required formats and background variants, and a fully interactive Figma prototype covering the complete website experience.

# What we took away from this.

## Good work takes rounds

The best version of almost everything in this project came in round 2 or 3, not round 1. Getting attached to a first draft is how you end up with something safe.

## Starting with research actually works

We were skeptical that doing all the strategy first would slow us down. It didn't — it made every visual decision faster and easier to defend, because we always knew why.

## Individual thinking first

Having everyone develop ideas separately before any group discussion meant we actually had different directions to choose from. It's easy to skip that step, but it matters.

**What we're most proud of:** *We built something that feels like it belongs to the RTS Lab — not like a generic research lab template. The colors are bold, the reasoning is solid, and the whole system holds together. That's what we're most proud of.*

### Project Manager

İdil Kale

### UX Designer

Khadija Osman

### UI Design / Wireframes

Jasvitha Madine

### Animation / Logo

Alex Yusupov

### UX / Logo Concepting

Joshua Stubbs

This project was part of GIT 450/550 at Arizona State University. The client was the Responsible Technology and Society Lab, Human Systems Engineering. The brief asked teams to work as independent creative agencies — competing to have their designs considered for the lab's real visual identity. This is Team IGNIS's submission.

09 — FINAL DELIVERABLE

# See the full prototype.

Desktop and mobile · Six pages · Complete brand integration · Built in Figma.

[figma.com/proto/g1d9mp3738d1ulAsuksmjD/RTS-WEBSITE](https://figma.com/proto/g1d9mp3738d1ulAsuksmjD/RTS-WEBSITE) →

Team: IGNIS · GIT 450/550 · ASU · 2025-2026 · Idil Kale · Khadija Osman · Jasvitha Madine · Alex Yusupov · Joshua Stubbs